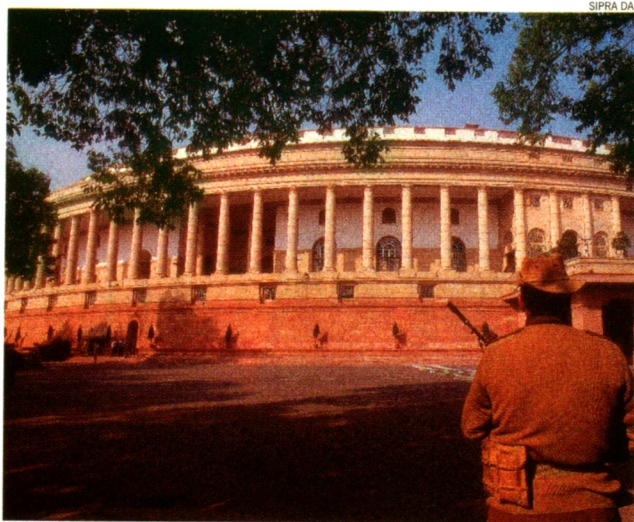




SIPRA DAS

A Different Agenda

DELHI With high decibels, angry walk-outs and adjournments dominating the current monsoon session of Parliament, legislative business has become the casualty. There are at least 26 government and 215 private members' bills mooted by individual MPs pending since the last Budget session.

Important government legislations such as those to provide social security for the unorganised sector are nowhere in sight. Thirty-six bills are lodged

with different parliamentary standing committees awaiting finalisation. Among them are socially meaningful legislations—the Maintenance and Welfare of Parents and Senior Citizens Bill (2007) and the Maternity Benefit (Amendment) Bill (2007).

Despite the magnitude of the crisis inside the Parliament over the Indo-US nuclear deal, the ongoing session has already witnessed three holidays, with another on September 4 for Janmashtami. Both Houses could work

STALLED: Pending bills are not in focus this session

effectively for 23 days if the four weekends are kept out of the count. But since the 14th Lok Sabha was constituted in mid-2004, not only has the size of sessions reduced but chaos inside Parliament has risen. Speaker Somnath Chatterjee has often reacted to acrimony within the Lower House without much effect. In the last Budget session, 19 of 27 pending bills had been introduced in the Lok Sabha.

Major parties are uncertain about the tenure of the 14th Lok Sabha given the current stand-off between the Congress and the Left. This probably explains the lacklustre attitude of the UPA Government in moving the pending bills. Parliament should perhaps take up seriously what one industrialist-turned-MP suggested—politicians who initiate and instigate parliamentary breakdowns should be fined. After all, every wasted minute costs the exchequer approximately Rs 25,000.

by Satarupa Bhattacharjya

SIGNPOSTS

SELECTED: M.N. Bandhopadhyay, director of the National Institute of Technology, for the Socrates International Award, for his contribution to the field of engineering. The award will be conferred by the European Business Assembly.

ACQUITTED: By the Delhi High Court, former Union minister and Jharkhand Mukti Morcha chief **Shibu**



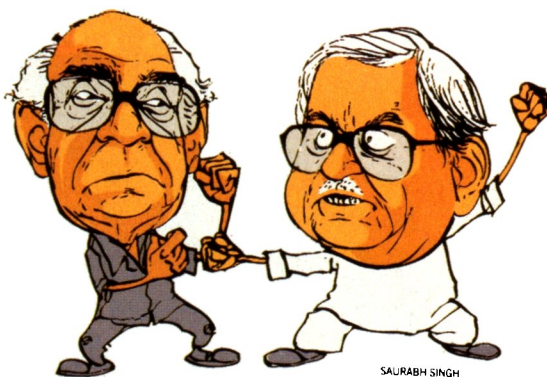
Soren of charges of murdering his former secretary Shashinath Jha.

DIED: Mahesh Baghel, BJP MLA from Keskal in Bastar and parliamentary secretary in the Chhattisgarh Government, when the car he was travelling in, overturned and caught fire near Raipur.

SUSPENDED: Orissa director-general of police, **B.B. Mohanty**, for sheltering his son Biti Mohanty, convicted for raping a German tourist.

VIS-A-VIS **M. K. PANDHE** CPI(M) Politburo member **versus** **BIMAN BOSE** CPI(M) Politburo member

If the Congress goes ahead with negotiations (on the nuclear deal), we won't hesitate to pull the plug (on the Government).



SAURABH SINGH

The withdrawal of support to the Government is a demand being placed from sections of the CPI(M) Talibans in Delhi.

EPILOGUE: A party divided within its ranks cannot be expected to work in unity with the Government.